



In this undated painting Attila the Hun is shown with his army—he is said to have been turned aside from sacking Rome only by the pleas of Pope Leo I.

“ [HUNS] TOOK CAPTIVE THE CHURCHES AND SLEW THE MONKS AND MAIDENS.”

Callinicus, disciple of Hypatius, from *Life of Saint Hypatius*, c. 450

IN JAPAN, THE 5TH CENTURY SAW THE RAPID DEVELOPMENT and expansion of the **Yamato state**. Complex irrigation systems began to appear, and rulers built ever larger burial mounds, such as the 1,600-ft- (486 m-) long Nintoku mound. **Ojin** founded a new line of kings, who exercised firmer control over Japan's main islands from a royal center in the Kawachi-Izumi area. Yamato

overseas contacts became more extensive, with ten diplomatic missions visiting China between 421 and 478, and increasing Yamato interference in civil wars between the Korean states of Paekche, Silla, and Koguryo.

The **Sasanian Persian Empire** came under pressure from eastern nomadic groups in the later 5th century. The **Hephthalite Huns** moved into Bactria early in the century, and were a particular threat to the Sasanians, but a famine during the **reign of Peroz (457–84)** caused them to move west again. In 469 Peroz suffered a terrible defeat at the hands of the Hephthalites. He was captured, and only released after leaving his son as a hostage. In 484, Peroz sought revenge in a new campaign against the Hephthalites, but was defeated and killed.

Having demanded, and been refused, the hand in marriage of Honoria, the sister of Roman Emperor Valentinian III in 450, the **Hunnish king Attila** (see 401–450) marched into Gaul. He was defeated near **Châlons** by an army of Romans under Aëtius and Goths under Theodoric.



Clay bear figurine

Clay haniwa figurines have been a feature of rich Japanese burials since the earliest times. The large burial mounds of Yamato rulers contain huge quantities of them.

Undaunted, Attila invaded Italy in 452, but turned back short of Rome. **Attila died** after his wedding feast in 453, and his sons began a civil war that led to the Hunnish empire falling apart.

Following the death of the Roman general Aëtius in 454, real **power in the western Roman Empire** was exercised by a series of barbarian kingmakers, such as **Ricimer**, the leader of the Roman army in Italy. In 457, Ricimer placed **Majorian** on the imperial throne. When Majorian became too independent-minded, Ricimer replaced him with **Libius Severus** (r. 461–65), who he later had poisoned. Deprived of effective leadership, the Roman Empire lost more of its Gallic territories to the **Visigoths** and **Franks**.



The baptism of Clovis the first: Clovis's baptism made him an easier diplomatic partner for the eastern Roman Empire than his Arian neighbors.

IN 456, THE VISIGOTHS,

encouraged by the western Roman emperor Avitus, had invaded the Iberian Peninsula. The Visigothic king **Theodoric II** (r. 453–66) defeated the Suevic ruler **Rechiarus**, who was threatening the Roman province of Tarraconensis, and the remaining Sueves retreated. Theodoric took most of Spain for himself, but left the Romans parts of the east coast. This policy was reversed by his successor

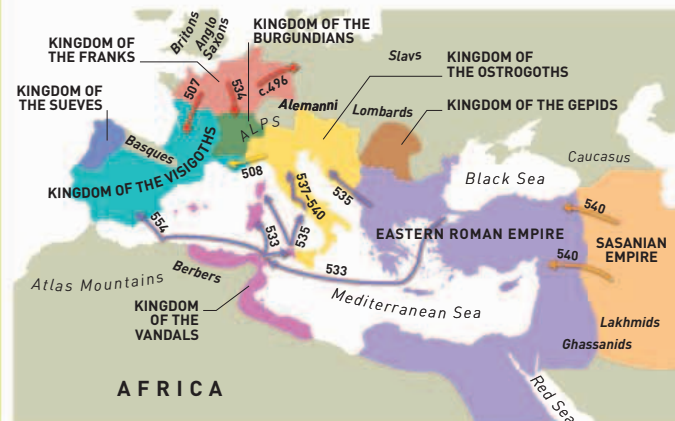
Euric (r. 466–84), who overran the remaining Roman territories in the late 470s. By the time of **Alaric II** (r. 484–507) the Visigothic kingdom encompassed almost all of Spain, as well as Aquitaine and Provence in southern Gaul. The situation in Spain was

repeated elsewhere in the Roman Empire, and the area of imperial control shrank to little more than Italy. **Anthemius** (r. 467–472) tried to recover some ground, but an expeditionary force against Vandal-controlled North Africa in 468 ended in disaster. In Gaul, Euric conquered almost all remaining Roman territory in the south by 475. In 472, Anthemius was overthrown by **Gundobad**, a Burgundian. Gundobad placed **Olybrius** (r. 472) and **Glycerius** (r. 473–74) on the throne in quick succession, but, despairing of the empire's frailty, he then left for Burgundy. The last embers of the empire were contested in 475–76, between **Julius Nepos** and **Romulus Augustulus**, the son of **Orestes**, commander of the Roman army. Feeling that the



Pope Leo I

The illustration on this manuscript shows Pope Leo I, an Italian aristocrat, persuading Attila the Hun not to attack Rome.



Barbarian kingdoms in Europe c. 500

By 500, most of the former western Roman Empire was divided among several principal barbarian successor states: the Vandals in North Africa, the Visigoths in Spain and southern Gaul, and the Ostrogoths in Italy.

KEY

- Byzantine reconquests
- Frankish expansion
- Ostrogothic expansion
- Sasanian expansion

